

Cybercrime Type: Cyberbullying

Case Study: Campaign Against a High School Student

In 2022, a 15 year old girl Maya, a high school student in Mumbai became the target of a cyberbullying campaign.

Cyberbullying means the use of social media platforms, messaging apps, gaming platforms to harass, humiliate, or intimidate other people online repeatedly and with malicious intent.

How It Happened:

1. A misunderstanding led a group of students to create a fake Instagram account under Maya's name and using her photos. They began with posting embarrassing, AI edited images.
2. The "bullies" used whatsapp groups to share private screenshots of her old messages, adding negative commentary. They encouraged others to join in, which caused expand in the audience.
3. The online bullying became real life. Anonymous confession pages on Instagram invited others to post hateful comments about her appearance and character. She was excluded from groups and received negative messages about her.

Target & Consequences:

Teenagers and young adults are the most likely to be targets of incidents like this, but cyberbullying can affect anyone. The consequences for Maya were devastating for her. Her academic performance was affected negatively as she refused to attend her school or interact with others. She suffered from various mental issues like anxiety, depression, self esteem issues and social isolation. Even after the fake accounts were reported and removed, the mental damage caused stayed. This highlights how cyberbullying can destroy a victim's mental health, reputation and sense of safety more relentlessly than traditional bullying in times like today since everyone prefers being online on social platforms.